

DINSHA J. PATEL

Last But Not the Least

Modi's Congress opponent is an 11-time winner whose only loss was in the Hindutva wave during the 2002 elections

It is difficult to fight an election against someone who in his election speeches combines gutter politics and development in equal measures. For the Congress leadership, it wasn't an easy task finding not just the right candidate, but a credible candidate to take on Narendra Modi. Its first choice was Shankersinh Vaghela, who knows all about Modi since the two had once been BJP stablemates, but the Union textile minister's answer was a flat "no". The party, then reportedly approached a noted danseuse whose response was no different and then an eminent Gandhian. It was then that the leadership zeroed in on Dinsha J. Patel.

A no-holds-barred speech that Patel, minister of state for petroleum delivered last year at a function in Ahmedabad, quite contrary to his normal temper, is still remembered by many in the state: "The man sitting in Gandhinagar is an epitome of hypocrisy and falsehood. One doesn't know where the Gujarat of Gandhiji and Sardar Patel will land under this dispensation. Let us all unite to free Gujarat from this misrule". It was as if, a year later, the gods sitting at 24, Akbar Road, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) headquarters, had heard his plea and now asked him to lead from the front.

Respected across party lines for his integrity and image, Patel is a high school dropout who cut his teeth in politics under the late chief minister Babubhai Jashbhai Patel in the old Gandhian school that was the Janata Party before that crowd shifted to the Congress in the post-Babri political upheaval of early 1990s.

He won five consecutive elections to the state Assembly since 1975 and in 1996 entered the Lok Sabha for the first time and then won three subsequent elections. His only defeat was in 2002 when he succumbed to the Hindutva wave that swept the state during the Assembly elections that came a few months after the Godhra carnage. On the other hand is his high-profile opponent, who is an electoral novice fighting only the second popular election in his career. With the kind of upbeat and aggressive mood that the Gujarat chief minister is demonstrating along with the strong pro-Modi undercurrent that's visible, it is unlikely that he will tie himself down to Maninagar in the fear of Patel, who described the ensuing elections as a "*dharm yudh*". But what is now assured is plenty of fireworks, and some even hitting below-the-belt.

by Uday Mahurkar

BJP more than doubled its women candidates against 11 of the Congress.

Nevertheless, both the parties are facing issues that may be later termed as wrong tactics. BJP has, in its squad, many sitting MLAs who are facing anti-incumbency in their respective constituencies. The Congress seems to have gone wrong in balancing caste and area-wise representation. It has not fielded any Muslim candidate from Kutch that has over 20 per cent Muslim population, which prompted protests by Muslim party workers in Abdasa. Also, in Patel-dominated Mehsana the fielding of former state minister Naresh Raval has led to protests. BJP spokesperson Vijay Rupani says, "The Congress has given us these seats on a



SQUEAKY CLEAN: Patel after filing his nomination papers

platter by way of wrong political calculation." But, Gujarat Congress General Secretary Dipak Babaria says, "When you carry out such an exercise there is bound to be some unrest. But it will cool down. The struggle for tickets shows that the party is fully geared to take on BJP. In fact, it is BJP's failure to replace candidates facing anti-incumbency, which will prove costly for it."

Interestingly, BJP suffered a jolt when it failed to prevent Uma Bharati from withdrawing from the state by holding out the bait of a re-entry into the party—BJP rebels in her party virtually bulldozed her into refusal. ■